Congress of the United States
Washington, DC 20515

July 23, 1998

The President
The White House
Washington, D.C. 20500

Dear Mr. President:

We write to express our concern about your recent remarks in China regarding the status of Taiwan.

While in China, you stated, "We don't support independence for Taiwan; or two Chinas; or one Taiwan, one China. And we don't believe that Taiwan should be a member of any organization for which statehood is a requirement." (These remarks followed your earlier alluding to the peaceful "reunification" of China.)

Mr. President, we have been assured repeatedly by your administration that your remarks do not represent a change in policy. However, the Taiwanese and, more ominously, the Communist Chinese, see them clearly as an emphatic, downright change in policy.

This is evidenced by Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesman Tang Guoqiang's July 9 statement that your remarks have "positive implications for the resolution of the Taiwan question," adding that "We hope that Taiwan's authorities will get a clear understanding of the situation, face reality and place importance on the national interest."

Small wonder that the unfailingly supportive Taiwanese have had a decidedly less upbeat assessment of a situation prompted by your public posture.

Mr. President, in all due respect, we are exceedingly troubled that a statement of policy by the United States has been interpreted so positively by a communist power which clearly does not share our values, and so negatively by one of our closest democratic allies.

This is surely due, at least in part, to the fact that these words have never before been used publicly by an American president on Chinese soil.

Moreover, it appears that your remarks are at variance with the language in the documents governing our relations with China and Taiwan, i.e., the Taiwan Relations Act, the three communiques signed with Communist China or the Six Assurances given Taiwan in 1982.

For instance, the word "reunification" does not appear in any of them. On the question of the status of Taiwan, the communiques did not openly state that we oppose independence for Taiwan; they merely "acknowledged" the Chinese position that Taiwan was part of China.

Section 2(b)(3) of the Taiwan Relations Act clearly declares that our policy "rests upon the expectation that the future of Taiwan will be determined by peaceful means." And points five and six of the Six Assurances are unambiguous on this question, as follows:

5) The United States would not alter its position about the sovereignty of Taiwan -- which was, that the question was one to be decided peacefully by the Chinese themselves -- and would not pressure Taiwan to enter into negotiations with China.

6) The United States would not formally recognize Chinese sovereignty over Taiwan.

On the question of Taiwanese membership in international organizations, section 4(d) of the Taiwan Relations Act states: "Nothing in this Act may be construed as a basis for supporting the exclusion or expulsion of Taiwan from continued membership in any international financial institution or any other international organization."

In 1994, testifying on your administration's Taiwan Policy Review, then-Assistant Secretary of State for East Asian Affairs Winston Lord told the Senate Foreign Relations Committee that the administration "will support its (Taiwan's) membership in organizations where statehood is not a prerequisite, and we will support opportunities for Taiwan's voice to be heard in organizations where its membership is not possible."

Mr. President, we respectfully request a response to the following questions:

1) Why did you declare our policy on Taiwan as you did, when you did and where you did?

2) Does your administration regard sections 2(b)(3) and 4(d) of the Taiwan Relations Act to be U.S. policy?

3) Are the Six Assurances, especially points 5 and 6, still U.S. policy? If not, why? If so, how does your declaration of policy in Shanghai comport with those Assurances, as well as with the three communiques and the Taiwan Relations Act?

4) In which organizations is the administration currently supporting Taiwan's membership? In which organizations is the administration supporting Taiwanese participation? Is the

administration prepared to lobby for changes in the charters of any organizations so as to allow for Taiwanese membership?

We will appreciate a timely response to these questions.

Kindest regards.

Sincerely,

Trent Lott

Jesse Helms

Benjamin Gilman